

THE TAJ MAHAL HOTEL DURING 26/11; HEADLEY (BELOW)



DELHI | Heart of Darkness

David Coleman Headley did not exactly sing like a canary while being questioned by a four-member team of the National Investigation Agency (NIA) in Chicago. It took the NIA's team leader, the seasoned Inspector General Loknath Behera, to ferret out information from Headley. What started as crumbs offered by the 26/11 Mumbai attack accused were pieced together by the NIA team into a meaty and poisonous pie, giving the Indians considerable insight into the operations of the Lashkar-e-Toiba in India and the planning of the Mumbai attacks. Granted access eight months after Headley was arrested by the FBI, sources said that much of the information may already be redundant. It would still, however, help investigators in understanding how 26/11 was organised, what Indian security loopholes were exploited and possibly provide information in nailing Hafiz Saeed, the role of the Pakistan Army, and the larger Lashkar plan to target India. The team questioned Headley on five occasions. Sources said that the exchange between Behera and the Lashkar operative was an interesting battle of wits. Behera used his persuasive questioning skills to make the hardened Headley talk. Formerly in the CBI, Behera has handled probes of the country's most sensational and sensitive cases, including the Purulia armsdrop case and the Graham Staines murder.

by Bhavna Vij-Aurora

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months after the FBI arrested Headley, the National Investigation Agency was finally granted access to him.